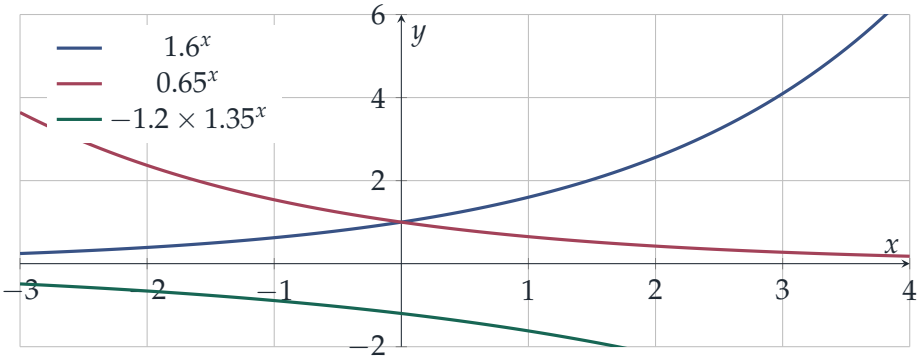
Chapter 2

Exponential Functions

Skills: model a continuous change, switch between representations, calculate, interpret

2.1 Core Course Notes

For $a > 0$, the function $x \mapsto a^x$ extends the integer powers of a to all real numbers. It satisfies $a^0 = 1$ and $a^{-x} = \dfrac{1}{a^x}$.



Key points

If $a > 1$, $x \mapsto a^x$ is strictly increasing. If $0 < a < 1$, it is strictly decreasing. For $f(x) = ka^x$, multiplying by $k < 0$ reverses the direction of variation. In every case, $a^x > 0$.

For $a > 0$ and all real numbers x, y:

$$a^{x+y} = a^x a^y, \qquad a^{x-y} = \frac{a^x}{a^y}, \qquad (a^x)^y = a^{xy}.$$

Common mistake

In general, $a^x + a^y \neq a^{x+y}$. The rules apply to products and quotients, not to sums.

2.1.1 Changes and average rate

A quantity with initial value V_0 undergoing a constant relative change with multiplier q is modelled by $V(t) = V_0 q^t$. If an overall multiplier Q results from n identical changes, the average multiplier is $q = Q^{\frac{1}{n}}$ and the average rate is $t = q - 1$.

Worked example

A company's turnover goes from 80 000 to 95 000 euros in four years. The overall multiplier is $Q = \dfrac{95\,000}{80\,000} = 1.1875$. The average annual multiplier is $q = 1.1875^{\frac{1}{4}} \approx 1.0440$: the average annual rate is therefore about 4.40 %.

2.1.2 Solving and interpreting

When both sides can be written with the same base, we use injectivity: for $a > 0$ and $a \neq 1$, $a^u = a^v$ is equivalent to $u = v$. Otherwise, a graphical or numerical solution gives an approximate value; the common logarithm (base 10), studied later, will give a formula.

Session 7 — Definition and direction of variation of a^x

Exponential Functions

6 Oct 2026 • B: 2 h – C: 1 h

Session objectives

- Make sense of a^x.
- Link the base to the direction of variation.
- Read curves.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

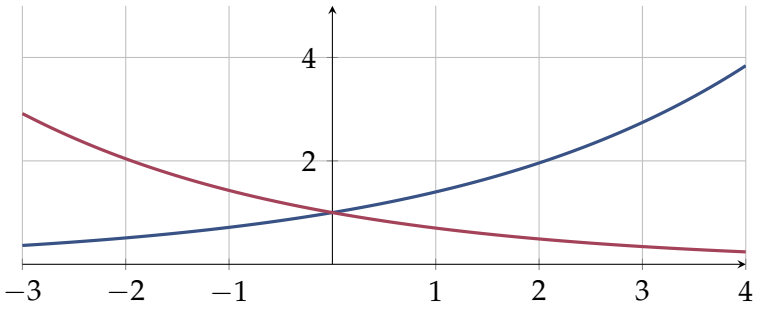
1. Write the multiplier for a 10 % increase. .....
2. Compare 1.04^3 and 1.04^7. .....
3. Calculer $2^4 \times 2^3$. .....
4. Write 5^{-2} as a fraction. .....
5. Is the function $x \mapsto 0.7^x$ increasing?? .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have the key words rephrased: make sense of a^x and link the base to the direction of variation.

Investigation

Using a calculator, complete a table of values of 1.5^x and 0.7^x for $x = -2, -1, 0, 1, 2, 3$. Plot the points, conjecture the variations and identify the point common to both curves.



Written record

For $a > 0$, a^x is defined for every real number x. The function is increasing if $a > 1$ and decreasing if $0 < a < 1$.

Worked example

Take the data from the investigation and write up the solution in this order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a sentence giving the answer. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Simplify $3^{x+4} \div 3^x$ and $(2^x)^3$.
2. Study the direction of variation of $f(x) = 4 \times 1.04^x$ and $g(x) = -4 \times 0.8^x$.
3. An initial value of 1350 increases by 4 % per year. Give the model and calculate the value after 6 years.

Textbook references

Further reading: Calao, course notes pp. 42–47; exercises p. 48, no. 1–8. The exercise reproduced in this session is identified below by its page and number; the reference also lets you find the figures and digital resources of the textbook.

Calao textbook – p. 48, exercise 2

On 1st January 2019, France has a population of 66.9 million. Its annual growth rate is estimated at 0.4 %. For every natural number n, let u_n be the population of France in millions on 1st January of year $2019 + n$, and assume that the sequence (u_n) is geometric.

1. Give the common ratio of the sequence (u_n). Express u_n in terms of n.
2. Suggest an expression for a function f that estimates the population of France x years after 1st January 2019, where x is a real number. According to this model, determine the population on 1st January 2022, on 1st July 2023 and on 1st October 2025.

Homework

Redo practice exercise 2 with the following data: replace the initial value by 155 and the rate or common difference/ratio by 3. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and give your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1, 2 and 3.

Session 8 — Powers and algebraic rules

Exponential Functions

8 Oct 2026 • B: 1 h – C: 2 h

Session objectives

- Transform powers.
- Use negative exponents.
- Spot a rule that does not apply.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

1. Simplify $3x + 4 - x + 2$. .....
2. Calculer $2^1 \times 2^3$. .....
3. Write 5^{-2} as a fraction. .....
4. Is the function $x \mapsto 0.7^x$ increasing?? .....
5. Compare 1.04^3 and 1.04^7. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have the key words rephrased: transform powers and use negative exponents.

Investigation

Simplify $2^3 \times 2^{-5}$, $5^{x+2} \div 5^x$ and $(3^x)^2$. Then invent a numerical counterexample to $a^x + a^y = a^{x+y}$.

Written record

$a^{x+y} = a^x a^y$, $a^{x-y} = \dfrac{a^x}{a^y}$ et $(a^x)^y = a^{xy}$. These rules require the same positive base.

Worked example

Take the data from the investigation and write up the solution in this order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a sentence giving the answer. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Simplify $3^{x+5} \div 3^x$ and $(2^x)^3$.
2. Study the direction of variation of $f(x) = 5 \times 1.05^x$ and $g(x) = -5 \times 0.8^x$.
3. An initial value of 1400 increases by 5 % per year. Give the model and calculate the value after 6 years.

Textbook references

Further reading: Calao, course notes pp. 43–45; exercises p. 49, no. 9–13. The exercise reproduced in this session is identified below by its page and number; the reference also lets you find the figures and digital resources of the textbook.

Calao textbook – p. 49, exercise 10

Write as a single power of 2:

$$a = 2^5 \times 2^3; \qquad b = \left(2^{4.5}\right)^3; \qquad c = 2^3 \times 4^2; \qquad d = \frac{2^5}{4}.$$

Homework

Redo practice exercise 3 with the following data: replace the initial value by 160 and the rate or common difference/ratio by 4. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and give your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1 and 2.

Session 9 — Functions $x \mapsto ka^x$: variation and graph

Exponential Functions

13 Oct 2026 • B: 2 h – C: 1 h

Session objectives

- Study ka^x.
- Combine sign and variation.
- Link formula and graph.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

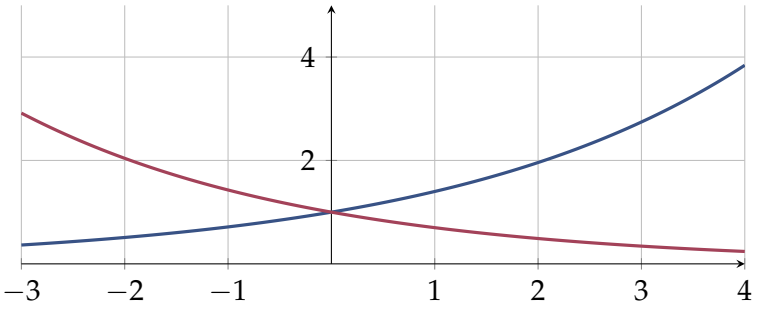
1. Calculate 20 % of 100. .....
2. Write 5^{-2} as a fraction. .....
3. Is the function $x \mapsto 0.7^x$ increasing?? .....
4. Compare 1.04^3 and 1.04^7. .....
5. Calculer $2^2 \times 2^3$. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have the key words rephrased: study ka^x and combine sign and variation.

Investigation

Match the four functions 2^x, 0.6^x, -2^x and -0.6^x to four curves. Justify each choice using the sign, the y-intercept and the direction of variation.



Written record

For $f(x) = ka^x$, the sign is that of k. If $k < 0$, multiplying by k reverses the direction of variation of a^x.

Worked example

Take the data from the investigation and write up the solution in this order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a sentence giving the answer. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Simplify $3^{x+6} \div 3^x$ and $(2^x)^3$.
2. Study the direction of variation of $f(x) = 6 \times 1.06^x$ and $g(x) = -6 \times 0.8^x$.
3. An initial value of 1450 increases by 6 % per year. Give the model and calculate the value after 6 years.

Textbook references

Further reading: Calao, course notes pp. 44–47; exercises p. 48, no. 5–8, then p. 52, no. 31–36. The exercise reproduced in this session is identified below by its page and number; the reference also lets you find the figures and digital resources of the textbook.

Calao textbook – p. 48, exercise 6

Determine the direction of variation of the functions defined on $\mathbb{R}$ by:

$$a : t \mapsto -2 \times 1.4^t; \qquad b : t \mapsto 9.85 \times 0.95^t; \qquad c : t \mapsto 0.8 \times 2.25^t.$$

Homework

Redo practice exercise 2 with the following data: replace the initial value by 165 and the rate or common difference/ratio by 5. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and give your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1, 2 and 3.

Session 10 — Average rate of change

Exponential Functions

15 Oct 2026 • B: 1 h – C: 2 h

Session objectives

- Calculate an average rate.
- Distinguish overall and average rates.
- Interpret an exponent $\frac{1}{n}$.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

1. Write the multiplier for a 25 % increase. .....
2. Is the function $x \mapsto 0.7^x$ increasing?? .....
3. Compare 1.04^3 and 1.04^7. .....
4. Calculer $2^3 \times 2^3$. .....
5. Write 5^{-2} as a fraction. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have the key words rephrased: calculate an average rate and distinguish overall and average rates.

Investigation

The price of a service goes from 18 to 23.50 euros in five years. Calculate the overall multiplier, then the average annual multiplier and the average annual rate. Check by applying the change five times in a row.

Written record

If Q is the overall multiplier of n identical changes, the average multiplier is $q = Q^{\frac{1}{n}}$ and the average rate is $q - 1$.

Worked example

Take the data from the investigation and write up the solution in this order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a sentence giving the answer. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Simplify $3^{x+2} \div 3^x$ and $(2^x)^3$.
2. Study the direction of variation of $f(x) = 2 \times 1.02^x$ and $g(x) = -2 \times 0.8^x$.
3. An initial value of 1500 increases by 2 % per year. Give the model and calculate the value after 6 years.

Textbook references

Further reading: Calao, course notes pp. 47–49; exercises p. 49, no. 14–19, then p. 54, no. 47–50. The exercise reproduced in this session is identified below by its page and number; the reference also lets you find the figures and digital resources of the textbook.

Calao textbook – p. 49, exercise 18

A company's turnover increased by 38 % over three years. Calculate the average annual increase to within 0.1 %.

Homework

Redo practice exercise 3 with the following data: replace the initial value by 170 and the rate or common difference/ratio by 6. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and give your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1 and 2.

Session 11 — Reading graphical representations

Exponential Functions

3 Nov 2026 • B: 2 h – C: 1 h

Session objectives

- Read outputs and find the inputs that give them.
- Compare two models.
- Estimate graphically.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

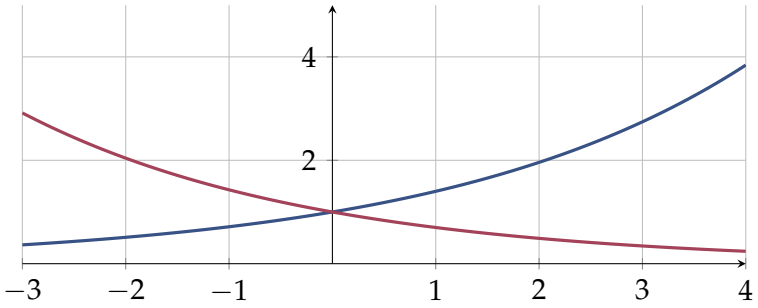
1. Simplify $3x + 7 - x + 2$. .....
2. Compare 1.04^3 and 1.04^7. .....
3. Calculer $2^4 \times 2^3$. .....
4. Write 5^{-2} as a fraction. .....
5. Is the function $x \mapsto 0.7^x$ increasing?? .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have the key words rephrased: read outputs and find the inputs that give them and compare two models.

Investigation

Two commercial offers are modelled by $f(x) = 120 \times 1.08^x$ and $g(x) = 180 \times 0.96^x$. Draw the curves on $[0, 12]$, read off their point of intersection and interpret the regions where each value is the greater.



Written record

Reading $f(x)$ means going from x to the curve and then to the y-axis. Finding an input for a given y means going from y to the curve and then to the x-axis.

Worked example

Take the data from the investigation and write up the solution in this order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a sentence giving the answer. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Simplify $3^{x+3} \div 3^x$ and $(2^x)^3$.
2. Study the direction of variation of $f(x) = 3 \times 1.03^x$ and $g(x) = -3 \times 0.8^x$.
3. An initial value of 1550 increases by 3 % per year. Give the model and calculate the value after 6 years.

Textbook references

Further reading: Calao, p. 52, no. 31–36. The exercise reproduced in this session is identified below by its page and number; the reference also lets you find the figures and digital resources of the textbook.

Calao textbook – p. 52, exercise 38

The functions f and g defined by $f(x) = 2.9^x$ and $g(x) = 0.35^x$ are plotted below.

1. Which curve represents f? Justify your choice.
2. Solve the equation $f(x) = 4$ graphically. Using a graphing calculator gives an approximate solution to within 0.01.
3. Determine graphically the set of real numbers x such that $f(x) \leqslant 4$ and $g(x) \leqslant 4$.

Homework

Redo practice exercise 2 with the following data: replace the initial value by 175 and the rate or common difference/ratio by 7. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and give your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1, 2 and 3.

Session 12 — Simple exponential equations

Exponential Functions

5 Nov 2026 • B: 1 h – C: 2 h

Session objectives

- Solve using a common base.
- Approximate a solution.
- Check plausibility.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

1. Calculate 5 % of 160. .....
2. Calculer $2^1 \times 2^3$. .....
3. Write 5^{-2} as a fraction. .....
4. Is the function $x \mapsto 0.7^x$ increasing?? .....
5. Compare 1.04^3 and 1.04^7. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have the key words rephrased: solve using a common base and approximate a solution.

Investigation

Solve $4^x = 64$, $9^x = \dfrac{1}{3}$ and $1.12^x = 2$: first using a common base when possible, then numerically for the last one. Bracket the last solution between two integers.

Written record

To solve $a^x = b$: use a common base when possible; otherwise bracket the solution or use a numerical tool. Check that $b > 0$.

Worked example

Take the data from the investigation and write up the solution in this order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a sentence giving the answer. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Simplify $3^{x+4} \div 3^x$ and $(2^x)^3$.
2. Study the direction of variation of $f(x) = 4 \times 1.04^x$ and $g(x) = -4 \times 0.8^x$.
3. An initial value of 1600 increases by 4 % per year. Give the model and calculate the value after 6 years.

Textbook references

Further reading: Calao, p. 52, no. 37–38, then p. 54, no. 45–46. The exercise reproduced in this session is identified below by its page and number; the reference also lets you find the figures and digital resources of the textbook.

Calao textbook – p. 52, exercise 33

Solve the inequality on $\mathbb{R}$: $0.8^x \geqslant 0.8^3$.

Homework

Redo practice exercise 3 with the following data: replace the initial value by 180 and the rate or common difference/ratio by 2. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and give your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1 and 2.

Session 13 — Modelling with an exponential function

Exponential Functions

10 Nov 2026 • B: 2 h – C: 1 h

Session objectives

- Build an exponential model.
- Identify the parameters.
- Predict and interpret.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

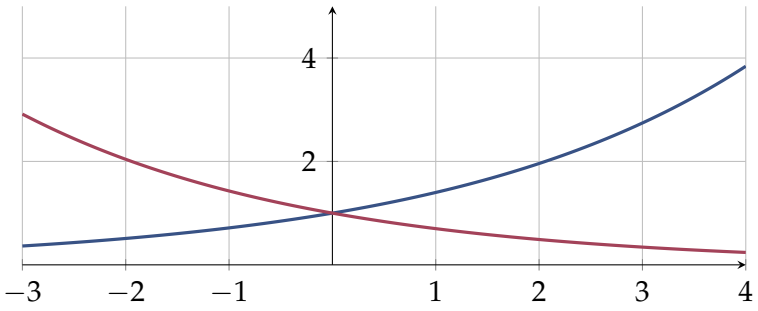
1. Write the multiplier for a 10 % increase. .....
2. Write 5^{-2} as a fraction. .....
3. Is the function $x \mapsto 0.7^x$ increasing?? .....
4. Compare 1.04^3 and 1.04^7. .....
5. Calculer $2^2 \times 2^3$. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have the key words rephrased: build an exponential model and identify the parameters.

Investigation

An app has 12 000 users at launch and its usage grows by 9 % per month. Build $f(t)$, calculate $f(6)$, then determine numerically when it will exceed 25 000 users.



Written record

A constant relative change with multiplier q is modelled by $f(t) = V_0 q^t$. V_0 is the initial value and q the multiplier per unit of time.

Worked example

Take the data from the investigation and write up the solution in this order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a sentence giving the answer. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Simplify $3^{x+5} \div 3^x$ and $(2^x)^3$.
2. Study the direction of variation of $f(x) = 5 \times 1.05^x$ and $g(x) = -5 \times 0.8^x$.
3. An initial value of 1650 increases by 5 % per year. Give the model and calculate the value after 6 years.

Textbook references

Further reading: Calao, p. 50, no. 20–25, then p. 53, no. 41. The exercise reproduced in this session is identified below by its page and number; the reference also lets you find the figures and digital resources of the textbook.

Calao textbook – p. 50, exercise 25

Atmospheric pressure equals 1 013 hPa (hectopascal) at sea level and decreases by 12 % each time one climbs 1 000 m. This is an exponential decay.
It can be modelled by a function P of the altitude h in thousands of metres satisfying: $P(h) = ka^h$.

1. Determine the constants k and a.
2. Calculate the pressure at an altitude of 5 500 m to within 1 hPa.

Homework

Redo practice exercise 2 with the following data: replace the initial value by 185 and the rate or common difference/ratio by 3. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and give your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1, 2 and 3.

Session 14 — Review and chapter assessment

Exponential Functions

12 Nov 2026 • B: 1 h – C: 2 h

Session objectives

- Use what the chapter has covered.
- Write up a modelling solution.
- Correct a mistake.

Fluency – 6 to 8 minutes, no calculator

1. Simplify $3x + 3 - x + 2$. .....
2. Is the function $x \mapsto 0.7^x$ increasing?? .....
3. Compare 1.04^3 and 1.04^7. .....
4. Calculer $2^4 \times 2^3$. .....
5. Write 5^{-2} as a fraction. .....

Reminder and prerequisites

Reread the last written record and be able to carry out the basic calculations needed today. Before the investigation, have the key words rephrased: use what the chapter has covered and write up a modelling solution.

Investigation

Using four pieces of student work, spot and correct: rate/multiplier confusion, a false power rule, an error in the direction of variation and a conclusion without a unit.

Written record

To validate an exponential model: identify V_0 and q, calculate with the units, check the order of magnitude and interpret the result.

Worked example

Take the data from the investigation and write up the solution in this order: definition of the objects, property used, exact or approximate calculation, then a sentence giving the answer. The model answer appears in the teacher edition.

Practice – essential

1. Simplify $3^{x+6} \div 3^x$ and $(2^x)^3$.
2. Study the direction of variation of $f(x) = 6 \times 1.06^x$ and $g(x) = -6 \times 0.8^x$.
3. An initial value of 1700 increases by 6 % per year. Give the model and calculate the value after 6 years.

Textbook references

Further reading: Calao, p. 54, no. 47–58. The exercise reproduced in this session is identified below by its page and number; the reference also lets you find the figures and digital resources of the textbook.

Calao textbook – p. 55, exercise 59

1. A share falls by 20 % one year, then by 80 % the following year. What is the average annual percentage decrease?
2. What is the average rate of change (percentage change) corresponding to an increase of 60 % followed by a decrease of 60 %?

Homework

Redo practice exercise 3 with the following data: replace the initial value by 190 and the rate or common difference/ratio by 4. Write it up in four lines: data, formula, calculation, conclusion.

Exit ticket – 3 minutes

On a half-sheet: write the main rule of the session, work through a very short example and give your confidence level from 1 to 4. Key question(s) of the day: 1 and 2.